The five survivors were arrested by the army and taken away to interrogation camps. [17]

Among the pilgrims who surrendered was a nineteen-year-old school teacher, Ranbir Kaur, who was staying in room 141 of Guru Ram Das Sarai with her husband and twelve children from a religious school she helped to run. She later told Mark Tully that she did not hear any appeals by the army to surrender or come out of the hostel. She thought they were safer inside and that the Indian army would not attack the temple. [18] Based on a petition moved in the Supreme Court in September 1984 by a Delhi-based social worker, twenty-two children who were picked up from the temple that day and lodged in Ludhiana jail were released. But most of them were subsequently re-arrested, on the plea that they had to be interrogated further for obtaining information about their relatives, who had probably been killed during the army operation. Ranbir Kaur was released at the end of August. She rejoined three of the children who had been released, but no one could tell her what had happened to the nine other children.

The hostel complex was eventually evacuated in the middle of the attack on the temple complex. Many innocent people were killed, many were injured and many were wrongly arrested. 'It was the least creditable part of Operation Blue Star.' [19]

The tanks roll in

As a part of the clearing-out process of the main temple complex, SFF commandos, 1 Para commandos and troops of 10 Guards were deployed to attack the Akal Takht from the main entrance side of the complex. Despite their repeated attempts, they failed to make a dent in the Akal Takht defences. In the process, the SFF and 1st Para commandos suffered heavy casualties. Additional troops from 26 Madras and 9 Garhwal Rifles, under the command of Brigadier A.K. Dewan, made another attempt to enter the Akal Takht. They too did not succeed, and suffered heavy casualties. At that point, Brigadier Dewan requested tank support.